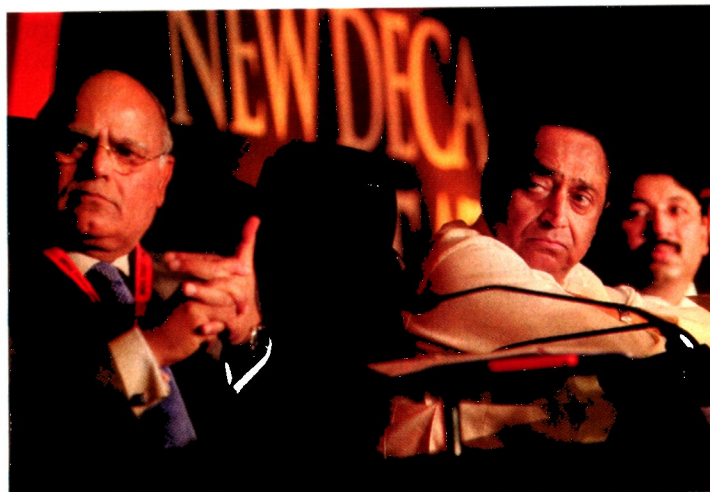


"The one billion population ensures that India grows"

DAYANIDHI MARAN UNION TEXTILES MINISTER

Today Mr Kamal Nath, Mr Nitin Gadkari or I can all be here and talk about growth. But at the end of the day when we go back to our constituencies, we need to be elected to come back in here. Because if we do something that doesn't get the voters' approval, they won't vote for us. And it is the one billion population which ensures that India grows.

When I became the telecom minister in 2004, the message from the prime minister was clear. It was growth, growth and more growth. There were 37 million cell-phones then. I said we should have 250 million connections by 2007. People laughed at me. But we achieved it. Then we set up a target of 500 million by 2010. We achieved it. Today, we have so many Tatas, so many Birlas amongst ourselves and that is a symbol of growth. When I became the minister of textiles, we beat the recession because of a strong domestic market. Before I end, I would like to quote Pramod Mahajan, who said the last time we were here four years ago, "We are from different political parties, we are all running a relay race, each one gets



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DAYANIDHI MARAN (RIGHT) AND KAMAL NATH (CENTRE) WITH SESSION CHAIRPERSON PRABHU CHAWLA

a chance to be in the government, to run a ministry, each one does his part, some may run faster, some may run slower, but everyone is trying to succeed. I am sure that we all will succeed."

For full speech and discussion, click to:
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DISCUSSION

Q. In politics can you take an economic approach to development rather than a political approach? Do freebies and subsidies hinder economic growth?

Kamal Nath: Every country does that. Take the US, the government there is bailing out banks. In the West, we see governments giving money to banks whereas in India banks are giving money to the government. We have to look at India in the context of distributed justice. It is not survival of the fittest; it is revival of the weakest. At the WTO, I asked the Americans about subsidy to their farmers, about \$20 billion they give, is it good economics or good politics?

Dayanidhi Maran: It is not only about giving freebies. During the recession the Germans came out with an idea of reviving the

economy and said because their country was mostly dependent on the auto sector they would give €5,000 for every car which was eight years old, provided one bought a new car. So, even Germany was into freebies. Politics and growth are related, and if politicians are doing that it is because of sheer necessity of democracy making them or forcing them to do so.

Nitin Gadkari: Populist politics is important, without that we cannot survive, but it should not become our mainstream politics.

Kamal Nath: We tend to forget that all countries are doing that but when it comes to India we become self-critical. Why are you giving free this or free that? In the US, 42 per cent of the cotton price is subsidy. Is it good politics or good economics?

Q. What are the two parties

doing to ensure that honest, middle class Indians, who want to get into politics to bring about change, are given a chance to get elected to Parliament?

Kamal Nath: There is no quota for urban middle class to come in. I came in from a rural constituency. I never looked around how I was going to come into the mainstream. It has to happen by a political process of joining a party because we are a democracy.

Q. In recent times we have seen parties adopt a bi-partisan approach to get legislations through. The Women's Bill is the latest. So my question is, are there more such examples that can be hammered out?

Nitin Gadkari: On the day I became BJP president, I appealed to the ruling party to start a dialogue

with the opposition parties. Let us be together in matters involving national interest. If the ruling party is ready to start a dialogue then there may be some policy decision on which there will be unanimity and the country will benefit.

Kamal Nath: We must recognise that dialogue in a political framework is very important. But I would like to make another point when we talk of coalition. Yes, there has been a coalition. And the Congress party in itself is a big coalition, representing all interests. We see this in the Cabinet, we see this in the different shades of opinion which are represented across the country because the Congress brings to the table all parts of the country, all sections of society and all shades of opinion.